Lesson 4

Anger

"Do not be quickly provoked in your spirit,
for anger resides in the lap of fools."
(Ecclesiastes 7:9)

Anger: a strong feeling of displeasure, hostility,
or antagonism towards someone or something,
usually combined with an urge to harm

God gets angry with human beings when they don't follow His commandments and when they are sinful and rebellious. Jesus Christ displayed "righteous anger," and this is the only form of anger acceptable for man to express. Other forms of anger are unacceptable, and are admonished throughout the scriptures.

Synopsis

God's Anger: The Lord our God is gracious, loving, forgiving, and compassionate.[1] He is slow to anger and rich in love.[2] However, when God is provoked sufficiently, His anger can be fierce.[3,4] For example, He destroyed the city of Sodom and Gomorrah because

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The LORD, the LORD, the compassionate and gracious God, slow to anger, abounding in love and faithfulness, maintaining love to thousands, and forgiving wickedness, rebellion and sin.
(Exodus 34:6-7)[1]

"The LORD is slow to anger, abounding in love and forgiving sin and rebellion."
(Numbers 14:18)[2]

Who knows the power of your anger? For your wrath is as great as the fear that is due you.
(Psalm 90:11)[3]

God's anger rose against them; he put to death the sturdiest among them, cutting down the young men of Israel.
(Psalm 78:31)[4]

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of their evil ways,[5] and His anger "burned" against the pharaoh when he would not let the Jewish people leave Egypt.[6]

God is a jealous God, and He gets angry when His people worship idols or other "gods," and when they forsake Him.[7-9] If we reject God's word, as contained in the Bible, and fail to follow His commandments, we should properly fear God's anger and wrath.[10] Fortunately, if we obey God's commands, humble ourselves before Him, and seek righteousness, we can shield ourselves from God's anger.[11]

The whole land will be a burning waste of salt and sulfur—
nothing planted, nothing sprouting, no vegetation
growing on it. It will be like the destruction of Sodom
and Gomorrah, Admah and Zeboiim, which the
LORD overthrew in fierce anger.
(Deuteronomy 29:23)[5]

Therefore the LORD'S anger burned against this land, so that
he brought on it all the curses written in this book.
(Deuteronomy 29:27)[6]

They made him jealous with their foreign gods and
angered him with their detestable idols.
(Deuteronomy 32:16)[7]

If you forsake the LORD and serve foreign gods, he will turn
and bring disaster on you and make an end of you,
after he has been good to you.
(Joshua 24:20)[8]

The gracious hand of our God is on everyone who looks to
him, but his great anger is against all who forsake him."
(Ezra 8:22)[9]

Great is the LORD'S anger that burns against us because
our fathers have not obeyed the words of this book; they
have not acted in accordance with all that is
written there concerning us.
(2 Kings 22:13)[10]

Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land, you who do what
he commands. Seek righteousness, seek humility; perhaps
you will be sheltered on the day of the LORD'S anger.
(Zephaniah 2:3)[11]

Christ's Righteous Anger: Jesus Christ showed anger when He drove the moneychangers out of the temple.[12] He also got angry when people doubted that He could heal a man's hand,[13] and when the Pharisees were being hypocritical.[14] These were instances of "righteous anger."

Man's Righteous Anger/Rebuke: Righteous anger is the only kind of anger that God permits for human beings, and even when we engage in this type of anger, we must be careful that we do not "cross over the line" and sin.[15] Whenever possible, we should rebuke our fellow man frankly,[16] but gently,[17] remembering our own

Jesus entered the temple area and drove out all who were buying and selling there. He overturned the tables of the money changers and the benches of those selling doves. *"It is written,"* he said to them, "*My house will be called a house of prayer, but you are making it a den of robbers."*
(Matthew 21:12-13) [12]

He looked around at them in anger and, deeply distressed at their stubborn hearts, said to the man, *"Stretch out your hand."* He stretched it out, and his hand was completely restored.
(Mark 3:5)[13]

"Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You are like whitewashed tombs, which look beautiful on the outside but on the inside are full of dead men's bones and everything unclean."
(Matthew 23:27)[14]

"In your anger do not sin": Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry, and do not give the devil a foothold
(Ephesians 4:26-7)[15]

Rebuke your neighbor frankly so you will not share in his guilt.
(Leviticus 19:17)[16]

Brothers, if someone is caught in a sin, you who are spiritual should restore him gently. But watch yourself, or you also may be tempted.
(Galatians 6:1)[17]

sinful nature and imperfections.[18] We are to correct, rebuke, and encourage "with great patience and careful instruction."[19]

Refrain From Anger: Unfortunately, man's anger is not always "righteous anger," and the Bible advises against most forms of anger.[20] In general, God desires that we refrain from anger[21] and keep ourselves under control.[22] Quick-tempered people often do foolish things,[23,24] and man's anger doesn't bring about the righteous life that God desires.[25]

God's Guidance

Watch What You Say: God wants us to be careful about how we talk to others.[26,27] Jesus reminds us that all men will have to give

There is not a righteous man on earth who does what is right and never sins.
(Ecclesiastes 7:20)[18]

Preach the Word; be prepared in season and out of season; correct, rebuke and encourage—with great patience and careful instruction.
(2 Timothy 4:2)[19]

Get rid of all bitterness, rage and anger, brawling and slander, along with every form of malice.
(Ephesians 4:31)[20]

Refrain from anger and turn from wrath.
(Psalm 37:8)[21]

A fool gives full vent to his anger, but a wise man keeps himself under control.
(Proverbs 29:11)[22]

A quick-tempered man does foolish things.
(Proverbs 14:17)[23]

Do not be quickly provoked in your spirit, for anger resides in the lap of fools.
(Ecclesiastes 7:9)[24]

Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to be become angry, for man's anger does not bring about the righteous life that God desires.
(James 1:19-20)[25]

an account on the day of judgment for every careless word they have spoken.[28] Reckless words can "pierce like a sword," and can do significant harm to others.[29]

Control Yourself: When provoked, try to remain calm and avoid shouting.[30] Step back and think about what you are going to say before you say it, and don't speak in haste.[31] Often, you can calm a quarrel by remaining quiet and being patient.[30-33] Remember that a "gentle answer" can defuse a situation and stop an argument from getting out of control.[34] In fact, if you control your

He who guards his lips guards his life, but he who speaks rashly will come to ruin.
(Proverbs 13:3)[26]

The tongue has the power of life and death.
(Proverbs 18:21)[27]

But I tell you that men will have to give an account on the day of judgment for every careless word they have spoken.
(Matthew 12:36)[28]

Reckless words pierce like a sword, but the tongue of the wise brings healing.
(Proverbs 12:18)[29]

The quiet words of the wise are more to be heeded than the shouts of a ruler of fools.
(Ecclesiastes 9:17)[30]

Do you see a man who speaks in haste? There is more hope for a fool than for him.
(Proverbs 29:20)[31]

A hot-tempered man stirs up dissension, but a patient man calms a quarrel.
(Proverbs 15:18)[32]

Through patience a ruler can be persuaded, and a gentle tongue can break a bone.
(Proverbs 25:15)[33]

A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger.
(Proverbs 15:1)[34]

temper and are patient, your gentle answer can prove to be a major "weapon" against your opponent.[35,36]

Keep Things In Perspective: Avoid foolish and stupid arguments; they only produce quarrels.[37] People who love to quarrel love sin.[38] Keep things in perspective, and learn to drop things that aren't really that important.[39] Don't pay attention to every word that people say[40] and try to "hold your tongue" before speaking;[41] develop good listening skills, and try not to respond without first hearing what the other person has to say.[42]

Don't Go to Bed Angry: If possible, try to resolve your anger with another person before you go to bed at night.[43] This may require

Better a patient man than a warrior, a man who controls his temper than one who takes a city
(Proverbs 16:32)[35]

Through patience a ruler can be persuaded, and a gentle tongue can break a bone.
(Proverbs 25:15)[36]

Don't have anything to do with foolish and stupid arguments, because you know they produce quarrels.
(2 Timothy 2:23)[37]

He who loves a quarrel loves sin.
(Proverbs 17:19)[38]

Starting a quarrel is like breaching a dam; so drop the matter before a dispute breaks out.
(Proverbs 17:14)[39]

Do not pay attention to every word people say.
(Ecclesiastes 7:21)[40]

He who guards his lips guards his life, but he who speaks rashly will come to ruin.
(Proverbs 13:3)[41]

He who answers before listening—that is his folly and his shame.
(Proverbs 18:13)[42]

Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry, and do not give the devil a foothold.
(Ephesians 4:26-27)[43]

that you forgive the other person, or ask the other person to forgive you.[44] Apparently the devil loves it when we go to bed angry and upset at each other.[43]

Stay Away From Angry People: Anger can be contagious. Scriptures warn us to stay away from people who get angered easily, and avoid making friends with hot-tempered people—so that we don't learn their ways and become angry people ourselves.[45] Hot-tempered people commit many sins,[46] and get into trouble a lot. If you rescue them from their trouble, you will probably have to do it again and again.[47]

Be Wise and Try to Live in Peace: Finally, if you are wise, you will learn to restrain your words[48] and your temper,[49] and turn anger away whenever possible.[50] Never try to stir up anger.[51]

Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you.
(Ephesians 4:32) [44]

Do not make friends with a hot-tempered man, do not associate with one easily angered, or you may learn his ways and get yourself ensnared.
(Proverbs 22:24-25)[45]

A hot-tempered one [man] commits many sins.
(Proverbs 29:22)[46]

A hot-tempered man must pay the penalty; if you rescue him, you will have to do it again.
(Proverbs 19:19)[47]

A man of knowledge uses words with restraint, and a man of understanding is even-tempered
(Proverbs 17:27)[48]

A fool gives full vent to his anger, but a wise man keeps himself under control.
(Proverbs 29:11)[49]

Wise men turn away anger.
(Proverbs 29:8) [50]

For as churning the milk produces butter, and as twisting the nose produces blood, so stirring up anger produces strife.
(Proverbs 30:33) [51]

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Make every effort to live peacefully with all men.[52] Love each other, as God loves us.[53] Remember that love is patient and kind; it keeps no record of wrongs, and it is not easily angered.[54]

Make every effort to live in peace with all men.
(Hebrews 12:14)[52]

Dear friends, let us love another,
for love comes from God.
(1 John 4:7)[53]

Love is patient, love is kind. It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud. It is not rude, it is not self-seeking, it is not easily angered, it keeps no record of wrongs.
(1 Corinthians 13:4-5)[54]